# Castalia Institute — Marketing Plan

*How we reach learners, build community, and grow revenue on a bootstrap budget*

FY 2026–2028 · Solo Founder · $0 Paid Marketing in Year 1

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# Marketing Objectives

## 6 Months

- 5K monthly Encyclopaedia readers
- 2K email list subscribers
- 300 Atlas founding cohort sold
- 50 paid members ($49/mo)
- 2% free → paid conversion

**Revenue target: $20K**

## 12 Months

- 15K monthly readers
- 5K email list
- 200 paid members
- 100 iNQ Card subscribers
- 300 Atlas devices shipped

**Revenue target: $114K**

## 24 Months

- 50K monthly readers
- 15K email list
- 1,500 paid members
- 800 iNQ Card subs
- 2,300 Atlas devices shipped

**Revenue target: $910K**

**Core constraint:** Solo founder, $3K in cloud credits, no paid marketing until cash-flow positive. Every dollar of growth must come from content, community, and product.

# Target Demographics: Homeschool Families

## Who She Is

**Primary buyer:** Mother, 30–45

**HHI:** $75K–150K

**Education:** College-educated (STEM or humanities)

**Location:** Suburban/exurban; TX, FL, CA, NC, VA

**Kids:** 2–4, ages 5–16

**Political lean:** Religious right AND secular progressive; united by distrust of institutional schools

## How She Thinks

**Philosophy:** Classical, Charlotte Mason, eclectic, "unschool with structure"

**Pain:** Juggles 5–10 resources; nothing comprehensive

**Buying triggers:** Peer reviews, convention demos, "my friend uses it"

**Price tolerance:** $500–2K/yr; will pay more if it replaces multiple tools

**Skepticism:** High toward Big Tech, AI hype, secular-only content

## Where She Spends Time

**Facebook** (daily): Well-Trained Mind (20K), Classical Conversations (100K+), state HS groups

**Pinterest** (weekly): Curriculum planning, lesson ideas

**Instagram** (daily): Homeschool lifestyle accounts

**YouTube** (weekly): Curriculum reviews, "day in the life"

**Podcasts:** Read-Aloud Revival, Brave Writer

**In-person:** Co-ops, conventions (THSC, FPEA, GHC)

**Market size:** 3.7M US students (~2M families) · **Addressable:** ~300K spending $500+/yr · **SAM:** $176M

# Target Demographics: Lifelong Learners & Autodidacts

## Who He Is

**Primary buyer:** Male 45–75 (female 35–65 secondary)

**HHI:** $80K–200K

**Education:** College-educated; many with grad degrees

**Location:** Urban/suburban; US, UK, Canada, Australia

**Occupation:** Retired pro, semi-retired exec, knowledge worker

**Identity:** "Reader," "thinker," "I never stopped learning"

## How He Thinks

**Currently using:** Wondrium ($20/mo), Audible, MIT OCW, Substack

**Pain:** MOOCs feel hollow, YouTube lacks structure, no progression, no peers

**Buying triggers:** Content quality, intellectual prestige, physical artifacts, community

**Price tolerance:** $20–50/mo learning; $200–500 physical; collects books

**Skepticism:** Anti-gimmick, anti-gamification; wants substance

## Where He Spends Time

**Reddit** (daily): r/philosophy (18M), r/AskHistorians (2M), r/autodidact (25K), r/slatestarcodex

**Twitter/X** (daily): Intellectual communities, longtermism, history

**Substack** (weekly): Astral Codex Ten, Intrinsic Perspective

**YouTube:** Wondrium, 3Blue1Brown, Philosophy Tube

**Podcasts:** Lex Fridman, EconTalk, Philosophize This!, In Our Time

**Goodreads, LibraryThing**

**Market size:** 72M US adults in continuing ed · **Addressable:** ~360K premium · **SAM:** $212M

# The Acquisition Funnel

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│  DISCOVER (free)                                          │
│  Encyclopaedia SEO · Apocalypso social · Reddit/Twitter   │
│  Target: 15K monthly readers by Month 12                  │
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│  ENGAGE (free, gated)                                     │
│  AI Faculty conversations (5/day free) · Email capture    │
│  Target: 5K email list, 30% email open rate               │
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│  CONVERT (paid)                                           │
│  Membership $49/mo · iNQ Cards $20/mo · Atlas $99-500     │
│  Target: 2% reader-to-paid, 200 members by Month 12      │
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│  RETAIN & EXPAND                                          │
│  Magisteria progression · iNQ Cards physical touchpoint   │
│  Course completion · Sam (SAMWISE) companion              │
│  Target: <5% monthly churn                                │
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**Key insight:** The Encyclopaedia is not a product we sell — it's the marketing engine. Every entry is a long-tail SEO page, a social media asset, and a gateway to the paid ecosystem.

# Channel Strategy Overview

| Channel | Cost | Expected Impact | Phase |
|---|---|---|---|
| **SEO** (Encyclopaedia + Bibliotech) | $0 | 483+ entries + 76K texts indexed | 1 |
| **Bibliotech / Commonplace / Feed + News** | $0 | Faculty marginalia + social proof + news takes | 1 |
| **Singh + Symposia + Map** | $0 | Lectures, 4 social formats, hex-grid curriculum | 1-2 |
| **Book Club + Homeschool + Table** | $0 | Reading groups, lesson plans, faculty TTRPG | 1 |
| **Organic social** (X, Reddit, FB) | $0 | Community seeding, 5-10 posts/week | 1 |
| **Email** (Buttondown/Loops) | $0-29/mo | Nurture + conversion, 2-3 emails/week | 1 |
| **Homeschool outreach** | $0-200/mo | Direct access to target segment | 1 |
| **Apocalypso hooks** | $0 | Topical virality, risk updates as content | 1 |
| **YouTube & TikTok** | $0-50/video | Atlas unboxing, Encyclopaedia readings | 2 |
| **Crowdfunding** | Platform fees | Atlas + TerrAIn launches, PR catalyst | 1-2 |
| **Conventions** | $300-800/event | Direct sales, credibility, feedback | 2 |
| **Podcasts** | $0 | Authority building, niche audiences | 1-2 |
| **Paid ads** (Google + Meta) | $1.5-3K/mo | Long-tail educational + parent targeting | 3 |
| **Affiliates** | 10-15% rev share | Scalable, performance-based | 2-3 |

# Channel 1: SEO — The $0 Growth Engine

**Why this works:** 483+ Encyclopaedia entries + 76,000 Bibliotech texts + 177 faculty bookshelves = massive indexable surface. Faculty marginalia in the Commonplace creates unique content no competitor can replicate.

## Keyword Strategy

**Long-tail** (rankable now): "Darwin on adaptation", "Kant on duty", "Tao Te Ching full text"

**Educational:** "philosophy curriculum homeschool", "classical education resources"

**Bibliotech primary sources:** "Rumi poems online", "Confucius Analects text", "Popol Vuh full text"

**Faculty marginalia** (zero competition): "Plato on Lewis Carroll", "Hypatia on Euclid"

**Singh lectures:** "Khan Academy with AI tutor", "learn calculus from Euler"

## SEO Actions (Cost: $0)

1. **Encyclopaedia:** 483+ entries, schema markup (Article, Author, Book)
2. **Bibliotech:** 76K catalog pages with title/author/archive metadata
3. **Faculty bookshelves:** 177 curated landing pages
4. **Internal linking:** Encyclopaedia → Bibliotech → Commonplace marginalia
5. **Content velocity:** 3-5 new entries/week + continuous marginalia
6. **Backlinks:** Educational directories, Wikipedia citation opportunities

## Expected Timeline

- Months 1-3: Indexing, minimal traffic
- Months 4-6: Long-tail queries ranking
- Months 6-12: Compound growth to 15K/mo
- Year 2: 25K-50K/mo as authority builds

# Social Media Playbook

## Facebook — Homeschool (5 hr/wk, $0)

Join groups (Well-Trained Mind 20K, Classical Conversations 100K+, state groups). **Answer first, link second.** Co-op demo offers. Saturday AM shares.

## Pinterest — Visual for Homeschool (3 hr/wk, $0)

80% women 25-54. Pins last 3-6 months. Curriculum planning, entry highlights, iNQ Card art, infographics. 5-10 pins/week via Tailwind.

## Reddit — High Trust (3 hr/wk, $0)

Build karma 4-6 weeks first. r/homeschool, r/philosophy, r/AskHistorians. Then AMA: "I built a 13-vol AI encyclopaedia."

## X/Twitter — Lifelong Learners (5 hr/wk, $0)

10-12 posts/week: Faculty quotes, Apocalypso hooks, build-in-public, threads, engagement polls. First-person founder voice. Engage @waitbutwhy, @AstralCodex, #buildinpublic.

## Instagram — Visual Showcase (2 hr/wk, $0)

iNQ Cards, Atlas, Encyclopaedia art. Feed (3×/wk), Stories (daily), Reels (1-2×/wk). Focus on saves.

## Phase 2 (M7+): YouTube, TikTok, Podcasts

YouTube: "Ask the Faculty" clips, Atlas unboxing, build-in-public. TikTok: #BookTok #LearnOnTikTok. Podcasts: 1-2 guest appearances/month.

# Channel 3: Content Calendar & Email

## Weekly Content Cadence

| Day | Content | Channel | Purpose |
|---|---|---|---|
| Mon | Encyclopaedia entry highlight | Social + Email | Traffic to new content |
| Tue | Apocalypso risk update | X/Threads | News hook |
| Wed | AI Faculty conversation excerpt | Social + Blog | Product value demo |
| Thu | Build-in-public update | X | Founder brand |
| Fri | Homeschool resource share | Facebook + Reddit | Relationship building |
| Sat | Encyclopaedia "deep read" thread | X | Long-form engagement |

## Email Marketing ($0-29/mo — Buttondown → Loops)

| Sequence | Trigger | Emails | Goal |
|---|---|---|---|
| Welcome | Signup | 5 / 10 days | Intro Encyclopaedia, Faculty, Apocalypso |
| Activation | No Faculty chat | 3 / 7 days | First AI Faculty conversation |
| Conversion | Free user day 14+ | 4 / 14 days | Convert to $49/mo |
| Winback | Churned | 3 / 21 days | Re-engage with new content |
| Digest | All subs | 1/week | Top entries, Faculty highlights |

# Channel 4: Crowdfunding & Product Launches

## Atlas Field Tablet — Founding Cohort (Q2 2026)

**Platform:** Open Collective + pre-order page

**Goal:** 300 units × $99 = $29,700

**Cost:** $0 (organic + email list)

**Launch sequence:**

1. W-4: Tease on social + email + build-in-public
2. W-2: Landing page live, "Notify Me" capture
3. W-1: Email list gets early access
4. Launch: Social blitz, Reddit, homeschool groups
5. W+1: Unboxing/prototype video
6. W+2-8: Drip campaign to remaining list

**Why it works:** Validates demand before manufacturing. 300 founding families = evangelists.

## iNQ Cards — Genesis Deck (Q3 2026)

**Platform:** Shopify + email list

**Goal:** 100 subs × $20/mo = $2K/mo run rate

**Cost:** $0 (existing community)

**Launch:**

1. Preview on social (Blake/Mucha art = shareable)
2. "Founding Subscriber" — first 50 get bonus NFC card
3. Unboxing video of first pack
4. Monthly "Card of the Month" social series

## TerrAIn — Kickstarter (Q1 2027)

**Goal:** 50 Home Kits ($599-899), 10 Research ($2K-4K)

**Cost:** Platform fees (~8-10%)

**Why Kickstarter:** Robotics + education = viral video. STEM-curious built-in audience.

# Channel 5: Partnerships & Events

## Homeschool Conventions (Phase 2, $2-4K/yr)

| Convention | Timing | Attendees | Cost |
|---|---|---|---|
| Great Homeschool Conventions (7 cities) | Mar-Jul | 5-10K | $300-600 |
| FPEA (Florida) | May | 8K | $400 |
| THSC (Texas) | Jul | 12K | $500-800 |
| Midwest Homeschool Convention | Apr | 5K | $300 |

**Bring:** Atlas demo, iNQ sample packs, Encyclopaedia excerpts, QR → free Faculty chat

**Per-event goal:** 50 emails, 10 memberships, 20 Atlas pre-orders

## Conference Presentations ($0)

- NVIDIA GTC — TerrAIn demo (Inception program)
- Maker Faires — Atlas + TerrAIn
- EdTech — Encyclopaedia + AI Faculty

## Strategic Partnerships

**Libraries & Museums** (Phase 2)

- Encyclopaedia institutional access
- Atlas as reading station kiosks
- 3-5 library pilots

**Homeschool Curriculum Providers**

- Memoria Press, Classical Conversations cross-refs
- Encyclopaedia as supplementary resource

**NVIDIA Inception** (Active)

- GTC demos, Isaac Sim for TerrAIn, press via NVIDIA

**Affiliate Program** (Phase 2, 10-15% rev share)

- Homeschool bloggers: Cathy Duffy, Hip Homeschool Moms
- Education YouTubers, classical ed influencers
- 15% of first 3 months membership

# Budget: Year 1 Breakdown

**Total Year 1 marketing budget: $2,940** (excludes infrastructure/hosting)

| Quarter | Key Activities | Cost | Expected Outcome |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Q1** (M1-3) | Domain/email setup, SEO audit + sitemaps, social cadence, Atlas pre-order page | $150 | Infrastructure live, 500 email subs |
| **Q2** (M4-6) | Atlas crowdfunding, community outreach, iNQ preview, first convention | $500 | 100 pre-orders, 1K email, 50 signups |
| **Q3** (M7-9) | iNQ Cards launch, second convention, YouTube launch, Atlas shipping | $700 | 30 card subs, 150 Atlas shipped, 2K email |
| **Q4** (M10-12) | Affiliate launch, holiday gift guide, year-in-review | $200 | 80 card subs, 200 members |

**Monthly recurring:** Email tool $29/mo × 10 = $290. Hosting covered by cloud credits.

**Reserve fund:** $1,000 for unexpected costs (shipping, tool upgrades, booth materials).

**Total: $150 + $500 + $700 + $200 + $290 + $1,000 = $2,940**

## Year 2 Ramp: $18-24K

Google Ads $12K (M15+) · Conventions $3K · Meta Ads $3K (M18+) · Affiliates ~$2K · Tools $1.3K

**LTV:CAC target: 12-24× · CPA: $30-60**

## Paid Ads Decision Triggers

- Begin Google Ads when MRR > $5K AND organic CPA established
- Begin Meta Ads when Google CPA < $60 for 3 months
- Kill any channel where CPA > LTV/3 for 2 months

# KPIs & Measurement

## North Star: MRR

Membership ($49/mo) + iNQ Cards ($20/mo)

## Funnel Metrics (Weekly)

| Metric | Tool | Target |
|---|---|---|
| Encyclopaedia page views | Plausible | +10% MoM |
| Unique visitors | Plausible | 5K → 15K by M12 |
| Email list size | Buttondown/Loops | +200/mo |
| Email open rate | Email tool | > 35% |
| Free → Faculty chat | Supabase | 20% of visitors |
| Faculty → email capture | Supabase | 30% of chatters |
| Email → paid member | Stripe | 2-3% |
| Monthly churn | Stripe | < 5% |

## Channel Metrics (Monthly)

| Channel | Primary Metric | Target |
|---|---|---|
| SEO | Organic sessions | +15% MoM |
| Social (X/Reddit) | Referral traffic | 5K followers M12 |
| Email | Conversion to paid | > 2% |
| Crowdfunding | Units vs. target | 300 Atlas, 100 Cards |
| Conventions | Signups per event | 50+ |
| Podcast | UTM attribution | 100+ signups/yr |

## Reporting Cadence

- **Daily:** Social engagement, new signups
- **Weekly:** Funnel metrics, email performance
- **Monthly:** Channel ROI, MRR, churn
- **Quarterly:** Strategy review, reallocation

# 12-Month Roadmap

| Quarter | Key Activities | Milestones |
|---|---|---|
| **Q1** (M1-3) FOUNDATION | Encyclopaedia Vols IV-VI · SEO infrastructure · Social cadence (5-10/wk) · Email sequences · Atlas pre-order page | 500 email subs · 10 HS groups contacted |
| **Q2** (M4-6) LAUNCH | Atlas crowdfunding (300 units) · Vols VII-VIII · First convention booth · Podcast appearances (2-3) | 2K email · 50 paid members · $29.7K crowdfund |
| **Q3** (M7-9) EXPANSION | iNQ Cards live ($20/mo) · Atlas shipping · Vols IX-X · YouTube launch | 3.5K email · 120 members · 50 card subs |
| **Q4** (M10-12) SCALE PREP | Vols XI-XII (all 13 done) · Holiday campaign · Affiliate launch (5-10) · Library pilots (3-5) | 200 members · 100 card subs · **$114K rev** |

# Risks & Contingencies

| Risk | Prob. | Impact | Mitigation | Contingency |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| SEO doesn't compound | Med | High | Consistent publishing, backlinks | Shift to paid social earlier |
| Atlas crowdfunding undersells | Med | Med | 2K email list before launch, $99 price | Reduce batch to 150 units |
| $49/mo too expensive | Med | High | Generous free tier (5 chats/day + Encyclopaedia) | Test $29/mo or annual $399/yr |
| iNQ Cards low retention | Med | Med | Outstanding first 3 packs, collector mechanics | Quarterly premium box instead |
| Convention ROI unclear | Low | Low | UTM codes per event, email for swag | Drop events → Google Ads |
| Solo founder bandwidth | High | High | AI-augmented workflow, ruthless priority | Hire Content Lead M8-10 |
| Homeschool skepticism | Med | Med | Lead with free value, never sell in groups | Partner with trusted voices |

# Year 1 P&L Forecast

| | Q1 | Q2 | Q3 | Q4 | Total |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Memberships | $2K | $8K | $15K | $25K | **$50K** |
| iNQ Cards | — | — | $3K | $9K | **$12K** |
| Atlas Hardware | — | $15K | $12K | $10K | **$37K** |
| Publications | $2K | $3K | $5K | $5K | **$15K** |
| **Total Revenue** | **$4K** | **$26K** | **$35K** | **$49K** | **$114K** |
| Tools & Email | $100 | $137 | $237 | $237 | **$711** |
| Conventions | — | $500 | $500 | — | **$1,000** |
| Content & Misc | $50 | $100 | $200 | $200 | **$550** |
| Reserve | — | — | — | — | **$1,000** |
| **Total Marketing** | **$150** | **$737** | **$937** | **$437** | **$3,261** |
| **Mktg as % Rev** | 3.8% | 2.8% | 2.7% | 0.9% | **2.9%** |

## Why This Works on $3K

1. **Encyclopaedia is the marketing.** 483+ SEO pages = $0 CAC
2. **Faculty demos sell themselves.** 2 min with Darwin > any ad
3. **Physical products = word-of-mouth.** Unboxings spread organically
4. **Community trust > paid reach.** One mom's rec > 1,000 impressions

## Year 2 Scaling Math

$114K Y1 revenue → allocate $18-24K (20%):

- Google Ads $12K → 200-400 members at $30-60 CPA
- Conventions $3K → 200 signups, 50 members
- Affiliates $2K → performance-only

Transition from organic-only to blended acquisition.

# Summary

**Year 1:** Content is the marketing. The Encyclopaedia, Apocalypso, and AI Faculty drive organic discovery. $3K total spend.

**Year 2:** Layer in paid channels after proving organic conversion. $18-24K spend, funded by Year 1 revenue.

**Year 3:** Blended acquisition at scale. Institutional pipeline. Hardware expansion. $50-80K marketing budget.

**The moat isn't marketing spend — it's content.** No competitor has a 13-volume encyclopaedia, 10,000 AI faculty, purpose-built hardware, and physical artifacts in one ecosystem. The marketing plan is to let people discover that for themselves, then make it easy to go deeper.

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